Beliefs about Refugee Integration in Germany: A Survey Experiment on Ukrainian and Syrian Refugees

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2 Literature Review and Conceptual Framework

2.1 Immigration Attitudes and Migrant Characteristics.

This thesis builds on a large body of literature showing that attitudes toward migrants vary by migrant characteristics. Previous research has examined the role of characteristics such as country of origin, cultural and religious background, language proficiency, education, skill level, migration motive, and legal status in shaping attitudes among the host-country population.

In their review article, Hainmueller and Hopkins (2014) examine different explanations of immigration attitudes and conclude that immigration attitudes are not generally associated with individual economic self-interest, such such as concerns about personal labor-market competition. Instead, immigration attitudes appear to be more strongly associated with broader economic and cultural concerns. Consistent with this conclusion, Hainmueller and Hiscox (2010) experimentally examine whether attitudes toward immigration reflect concerns about labor-market competition. They find that both high- and low-skilled natives prefer high-skilled over low-skilled immigrants. This pattern is difficult to reconcile with a simple labor-market competition mechanism and instead suggests that respondents place considerable weight on the skill levels of immigrants.

Moving beyond skill as a single characteristic, Hainmueller and Hopkins (2015) use a conjoint experiment to examine how multiple immigrant characteristics jointly shape attitudes in the United States. Their study shows that American respondents evaluate highly educated immigrants in high-status occupations more favorably, while immigrants without plans to work, with unauthorized entry histories, of Iraqi origins, or poor English proficiency receive less favorable evaluations. Interestingly, these preferences vary relatively little with respondents' own education, partisanship, and labor-market position. Together, these findings suggest that evaluations of immigrants depend on multiple characteristics of the migrant rather than predominantly on respondents' own economic position.

Bansak et al. (2016) extend this multidimensional approach to asylum seekers in the European context. Using a conjoint experiment conducted across 15 European countries, they show that preferences over asylum seekers depend jointly on economic, humanitarian, and cultural characteristics. Respondents are more willing to accept asylum seekers with greater employability, more consistent asylum testimonies, and higher vulnerability, while cultural distance and religion also substantially affect evaluations. In particular, Christian asylum seekers receive greater public support than otherwise similar Muslim asylum seekers. These findings demonstrate that evaluations of refugees reflect both perceived economic integration potential and group-level characteristics such as origin and religion.

Particularly relevant to the present thesis is the German vignette study by Czymara and Schmidt-Catran (2016), which examines how immigrant characteristics affect the acceptance of immigrants. Their results similarly show that evaluations depend on several characteristics simultaneously. Refugees, highly educated immigrants, and immigrants with strong German-language skills are evaluated more positively, whereas immigrants from culturally more distant countries and Muslim immigrants receive lower acceptance. Consistent with Hainmueller and Hiscox (2010), their results provide limited support for individual economic competition as the main explanation for immigration attitudes and instead point to the importance of migrants' individual and group characteristics, such as cultural and deservingness-related factors.

The importance of group-level characteristics can also be seen in theories of group position and perceived group threat. Blumer (1958) argues that prejudice should not be understood only as an individual's negative feelings toward members of another group, but can arise from how individuals perceive the relative position of their own group and an out-group. Quillian (1995) applies a related group-threat perspective to anti-immigrant prejudice in Europe and shows that prejudice can be associated with perceived collective threat, including the relative size and economic conditions of immigrant groups. These perspectives suggest that attitudes toward migrants may also depend on how migrant groups and their position in the host country are perceived, which motivates considering respondents' group-level perceptions in addition to their evaluations of individual migrant profiles.

At the same time, recent evidence from Germany continues to emphasize the importance of migrants' expected economic contribution. Wolff et al. (2025) use a factorial survey experiment to examine citizens' willingness to accept skilled workers from outside the EU. They find higher acceptance for migrants who have a definite job offer, higher and certified professional qualifications, and good language skills, while labor shortages also increase acceptance. These findings demonstrate how human capital, language proficiency, and expected employability and economic contribution strongly influence attitudes toward migrants in Germany. However, the study focuses only on skilled labor migration and does not compare labor migrants with refugees or vary country of origin. In this thesis, I extend this perspective by considering migration status alongside country of origin and individual characteristics to be able to compare beliefs about Ukrainian and Syrian refugees and labor migrants within the same experimental design.

Taken together, these studies show that evaluations of migrants depend on both individual characteristics, particularly human capital and language proficiency, and group-level characteristics such as country of origin and migration status. They also emphasize the usefulness of factorial survey experiments for differentiating the effects of several migrant characteristics that would otherwise occur simultaneously.

Building on this literature, the proposed experiment varies country of origin, migration status, skill level, language proficiency, and gender. However, while much of the existing literature examines attitudes toward migrants and preferences regarding their acceptance, residence, and employment, this thesis focuses on respondents' beliefs about migrants' expected outcomes. In particular, I examine expectations concerning labor-market success, discrimination, and social integration.

2.2 Ukrainian and Syrian Migrants and Refugees.

2.3 Beliefs, Expectations, and Misperceptions.

2.4 Contact, Personal Experience, Information, and Memory.

3 Experimental Design

- i indexes respondents.
- j indexes vignette profiles.
- $g \in \{\text{Ukraine}, \text{Syria}\}$ indexes migrant groups.
- Y_{ij} denotes respondent i's evaluation of vignette j.
- C_{ig} denotes respondent i's contact exposure to migrant group g.
- Q_{ig} denotes respondent i's overall contact quality with migrant group g.
- M_{ig} denotes respondent i's media exposure regarding migrant group g.

General Notation: For inline equations, use .... For displayed equations, use

$$...$$

or the equation environment.

3.1 Target Population and Proposed Sample

3.2 Factorial Vignette Design

The study employs a factorial vignette experiment in which respondents evaluate hypothetical migrants whose characteristics are independently varied across profiles. This approach builds on previous factorial and conjoint experiments examining how characteristics of immigrants and refugees affect evaluations by host-country populations (e.g., Hainmueller & Hopkins, 2015; Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016).

The vignettes describe potential migrants who currently live in Germany and differ randomly across several characteristics. The description of immigrants is based on a total of five dimensions: country of origin (Ukrainian/Syrian), reason for immigration (war refugee/labor migrant), gender (male/female), language skills (low/good German), and education (low/high). Country and language skills describe the cultural distance. Distinguish between two levels: (1) low and (2) good German language skills. The education factor represents the human capital of the immigrants. Distinguish between a (1) low and a (2) high level of education, where: low level of education: completed secondary education but has no vocational or university degree. high level of education: has a university degree. It should also be taken into account that language skills also have an economic component. Success in the labor market depends, for example, on the ability to speak the local language. The effect size of language proficiency could exceed the effect sizes of religious affiliation and country of origin. However, it should be considered that part of the effect of language skills, in the sense of the human capital hypothesis, can also be attributed to economic considerations. (Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016)

Why religious affiliation is not included in the vignette: As discussed in the literature review, previous research demonstrates that religion and perceived cultural distance can influence attitudes toward immigrants (e.g., Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016). However, in this study, religious affiliation is deliberately not included as a randomized vignette attribute. The present study focuses on differences in expectations associated with migrants' country of origin, migration status, human capital, gender, and German-language proficiency. Introducing religion as an additional vignette dimension would increase the complexity of the experimental design. Moreover, explicitly providing information about religious affiliation could alter the beliefs that respondents would otherwise associate with Ukrainian and Syrian migrants based on the country of origin alone. Religion is therefore left unspecified in the vignette, allowing the country-of-origin treatment to capture respondents' overall beliefs associated with the respective national-origin group. Consequently, the estimated country-of-origin effect should be interpreted as a composite effect that may encompass perceived cultural and religious differences, rather than as an effect of nationality that is independent of religion. Respondents' own religious affiliation is nevertheless collected as a background characteristic and can be included as a control or examined in heterogeneity analyses.

Vignette wording: [Gender: Mr./Mrs.] [random letter]. came from [country of origin: Ukraine/Syria] to Germany. [He/She] came to Germany as [reason for immigration: a refugee after fleeing the war in [his/her] country / a labor migrant seeking employment opportunities in Germany]. [He/She] [skill level: has completed a university degree / has no formal vocational qualification], speaks German [language skills: well / only to a limited extent] and is currently looking for stable employment.

vignette universe: $2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 2 = 32$ profiles

male/female $\times$ Ukraine/Syria $\times$ refugee/labor migrant $\times$ high/low skill $\times$ good/limited German = 16 profiles

Each respondent receives only a few randomly selected vignettes. The randomization allows estimation of the marginal effect of each characteristic.

1. Explained vignette attributes: $Origin_j$ $MigrationStatus_j$ $Gender_j$ $Education_j$

$GermanSkills_j$

2. Choosing particular vignette attributes: Educational attainment is included because previous vignette and conjoint evidence consistently documents more favorable evaluations of highly skilled immigrants (Hainmueller & Hiscox, 2010; Hainmueller & Hopkins, 2015; Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016).L Language proficiency can be connected to Czymara & Schmidt-Catran and other relevant experiments. Migration status can be justified through the refugee-versus-labor-migrant literature. Country of origin obviously comes from your substantive Ukrainian–Syrian research question.

3.3 Outcomes Measures

3.4 Respondent Questionnaire

Citing measurement sources for the respondent questionnaire: C_{ig}^{Work} workplace contact frequency C_{ig}^{Social} social contact frequency Q_{ig} contact quality

Contact quality: The notation $Q_{ig} \in \{1, \ldots, 7\}$ denotes respondent i's overall contact quality with migrant group g. Contact quality is measured on a 7-point scale, where 1 indicates very negative contact experiences and 7 indicates very positive contact experiences. The measure is adapted to distinguish between the two origin groups examined in the present study.

$$PositiveExperience_{ig} = max(Q_{ig} - 4, 0)$$

$$NegativeExperience_{ig} = max(4 - Q_{ig}, 0)$$

Following the intergroup-contact literature, the questionnaire distinguishes between the frequency and quality of respondents' contact with members of the two origin groups. This distinction is motivated by previous evidence showing that the quantity and valence of intergroup contact constitute conceptually distinct dimensions and may have different relationships with attitudes toward refugees (e.g., De Coninck et al., 2021). Contact is measured separately for Ukrainians and Syrians and across workplace and non-work social settings.

Media exposure: $MediaExposure_{ig}$ Media exposure is measured separately for Ukrainian and Syrian refugees. Building on work conceptualizing refugee-related media exposure as a form of indirect intergroup contact (e.g., De Coninck et al., 2021), respondents report the frequency with which they encounter relevant news and media coverage. The measure is adapted to distinguish between the two origin groups examined in the present study.

Motivated by research showing that the memorability of information and narratives may influence subsequent beliefs (Graeber et al., 2024), the questionnaire additionally elicits whether respondents can recall a particularly salient personal experience involving members of either origin group and, if so, the valence of that experience.

Belief about migrant integration:

$$\underbrace{C_{ig}^{Work}}_{\text{respondent's workplace exposure}} \longrightarrow \underbrace{\text{beliefs about labor-market outcomes}}_{\text{potential association}}$$

$$\underbrace{C_{ig}^{Social}}_{\text{respondent's non-work social exposure}} \longrightarrow \underbrace{\text{beliefs about social integration}}_{\text{potential association}}.$$

Beliefs about large communities and network effects:

Large community $\rightarrow$ More information/referrals $\rightarrow$ Better employment

versus

Large community $\rightarrow$ Less native interaction $\rightarrow$ Slower integration.

Construct:

$\Delta B_i^{\text{Network}} = B_{i,\text{S}}^{\text{Network}} - B_{i,\text{U}}^{\text{Network}}$

3.5 Randomization and Survey Procedure

4 Empirical Strategy and Identification

Identification and equations: Baseline equation:

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \beta_1 Ukr_j + \beta_2 Ref_j + \beta_3 Female_j + \beta_4 HighSkill_j + \beta_5 German_j + \varepsilon_{ij}.$$

Adjusted specification:

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \beta_1 Ukr_j + \beta_2 Ref_j + \beta_3 Female_j + \beta_4 HighSkill_j + \beta_5 German_j + \boldsymbol{\delta}'\mathbf{X}_i + \varepsilon_{ij}.$$

H4 regression with interaction term:

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \beta_1 Ukraine_j + \beta_2 Refugee_j + \beta_3 \left(Ukraine_j \times Refugee_j\right) + \boldsymbol{\gamma}'\mathbf{Z}_j + \varepsilon_{ij}.$$

where

$$\mathbf{Z}_j = \begin{pmatrix} Female_j \\ HighSkill_j \\ GoodGerman_j \end{pmatrix}$$

$$\mathbf{X}_i = \left(Age_i,\ Gender_i,\ Edu_i,\ Emp_i,\ Inc_i,\ Mig_i,\ East_i,\ Religion_i,\ Right_i\right)'.$$

Then,

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \boldsymbol{\beta}'\mathbf{Z}_j + \boldsymbol{\theta}'\mathbf{X}_i + \varepsilon_{ij},$$

where $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ is the vector of coefficients associated with the respondent controls, and $\mathbf{Z}_j$ is contains the randomized vignette characteristics and $\mathbf{X}_i$ contains respondent-level controls.

5 Limitations and Extensions

5.1 Extensions

5.2 Limitations and Identification Constraints

6 Conclusion

References

Statement of Authorship

I hereby confirm that the work presented has been performed and interpreted solely by myself except for where I explicitly identified the contrary. I assure that this work has not been presented in any other form for the fulfillment of any other degree or qualification. Ideas taken from other works in letter and in spirit are identified in every single case.

Date: Signature: